

RELYING ON THE KINDNESS OF STRANGERS

Penn. man paddling his way to Gulf of Mexico

Story Discussion Image (2)

Font Size: - +

By TERRY PRATHER, Staff Writer | Posted: Tuesday, June 1, 2010 9:20 pm | (0) Comments

0 tweet

Recommend

Vincent Troia recommends this. Be the first of your friends to recommend this. · Admin Page · Error Unlike



Not satisfied with riding his bicycle across the United States last year from his home in Apollo, Penn., Matt Gavasto decided to embark on a journey in a kayak from Pennsylvania to the Gulf of Mexico.

Monday, day 17 of his trip, Gavasto showed up on the Ohio River bank near Bob and Sandy Drake's home.

"My son, Brian was working on his jet ski and this young man came ashore looking for shelter for the night," said Sandy Drake.

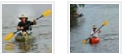
The Drakes live between the Ohio River and Kentucky 8 in the west end of Maysville.

After a brief conversation between Matt Gavasto and the couple, it was determined that the adventuresome 33-year-old was indeed looking for a place to sleep and rest up to continue his journey.

"I just wanted to stay near the river bank and get up early the next day to beat the afternoon heat," said Gavasto.

Terry Prather/Staff

Matt Gavasto paddles ashore below the William Harsha Bridge Tuesday morning. Gavasto was on his way from Pittsburgh, Penn., to the Gulf of Mexico.



Not buying into that request of sleeping in the mud, Sandy Drake thought it would be a better idea if he stayed inside the family camper.

"It was available and it would be better than sleeping on the muddy river bank," said Sandy Drake. "And besides that, we weren't using it."

"People have been incredibly nice to me. I stayed in a tour bus parked near the river last week. Another time I stayed on a house boat," Gavasto said.

While with the Drakes, Gavasto was talked into upgrading his small kayak to a larger one.

Dale Shellhammer, a neighbor of the Drakes volunteered to drive Matt to Maysville to see about a larger kayak.

Having found a nice replacement, the men returned to the river.

The new kayak is a bright orange compared to the basically camouflaged model that Gavasto paddled to Maysville.

Paddling around and putting the kayak into different maneuvers, Gavasto returned to the dock with a big smile on his face.

"Man, this thing is great," he said. "What control. I can probably go more miles a day easier."

Twenty-five miles a day is what he has averaged so far on the trip.

He travels very light, carrying only those things that are necessary for survival including a cell phone, a photo mounted in a weather-proof plastic frame, high energy snacks, and one change of clothes. The photo is of his parents. His mother died five years ago and he recently lost his dad.

"They passed on. I like to have it to where I can see it when times get tough," reflected Gavasto.

The snacks are whatever he can find in stores near the river. Rice cakes and lots of granola bars.

As for the two sets of clothes.

"I only have what I am wearing and one change of clothes," he said.

He has figured out how to take care of taking a shower and washing his clothes at the same time.

"I take a shower with my clothes on. I wash them while showering, remove them, wring them out and then take a shower,"

As far as the second set of clothes, he only wears them for sleeping inside of someone's home.

"I don't want to wear my dirty clothes inside of someone's nice house," said Gavasto.

He also carries a machete to guard against snakes he encounters.

"People I can usually deal with, but snakes are another story."

Gavasto plans on arriving at the Gulf of Mexico around the end of July.

"Once there, I will ship the kayak back home and enjoy a week's vacation in a cabin that me and friends rented."

So it is important for him to stay on schedule.

"I got an investment in the cabin and don't want to lose out on it," he said.

What's next for Gavasto?

"I think I'm going to walk the Appalachian Trail," he said.

For more area news, visit www.maysville-online.com.